Changes Worth Writing Down: A Memory and Daily Life Check-In

Ten everyday changes families tend to notice first, what to write down about each, and how to bring your notes to Mom's doctor.

You've noticed something. Maybe it's the same question twice in an hour, or the bills in a pile that used to be paid on the day they arrived. This page doesn't tell you what it means; it can't, and nothing you read online can. It helps you notice clearly, write it down the way a doctor can use, and have the conversation.

The ten changes below are the ones the Alzheimer's Association lists as worth a doctor's attention. Each one also has an ordinary explanation some of the time, which is why the notes go to the doctor and not to a conclusion. For each: what you saw, when it started, how often, and whether it is happening more than it did.

Memory and thinking

1 Recent conversations [1]

NOTICE The same question or story repeated within a short time, or recently learned information that doesn't stick. Needing the occasional reminder is different from relying on them.

WRITE DOWN What was repeated, roughly how often in a day, and when you first noticed it.

2 Familiar tasks [1]

NOTICE A recipe, a bill, a route to a familiar place, or the rules of a favorite game that used to be routine and now stalls partway.

WRITE DOWN The task, where it stalled, and whether it has happened before.

3 Plans and numbers [1]

NOTICE Trouble following a plan, keeping track of monthly bills, or concentrating on something that used to take much less time.

WRITE DOWN An example with its date; keep any paper that shows it, such as an unpaid bill.

4 The day and the place [1]

NOTICE Losing track of dates or seasons, or a moment of not knowing where she is or how she got there.

WRITE DOWN The date it happened and, as near as you can, what she said at the time.

5 Words [1]

NOTICE Stopping in the middle of a conversation with no idea how to continue, repeating herself, or struggling for a word and using another one that isn't quite it.

WRITE DOWN An example in her own words, if you remember them.

Judgment, mood and everyday life

6 Where things end up [1]

NOTICE Items put in unusual places, and trouble retracing steps to find them. Sometimes an accusation that someone took them.

WRITE DOWN What was misplaced, where it turned up, and how often this is happening.

7 Decisions about money [1]

NOTICE Poor judgment with money that is out of character: an unusual purchase, a telephone offer taken seriously, less attention to grooming or keeping clean.

WRITE DOWN The example with dates. Keep the paper: a receipt, a letter, a statement.

8 Seeing [1]

NOTICE Difficulty reading, judging distance, or telling colors apart; trouble with balance, or a change in how she drives.

WRITE DOWN What you saw and when, and whether anyone else has mentioned it.

9 Withdrawing [1]

NOTICE Dropping hobbies, social activities or a regular commitment she used to enjoy; trouble keeping up with a favorite team or activity.

WRITE DOWN Which activities, and since when.

10 Mood and personality [1]

NOTICE Becoming confused, suspicious, depressed, fearful or anxious; easily upset at home, with friends or when out of her usual routine.

WRITE DOWN What you noticed, in a sentence, and whether it is new or more frequent.

> **Sudden confusion is different**
>
> Everything on this page is about slow change, over weeks and months. A change that comes on over hours or days is a call to her doctor the same day, or to emergency services if she is in danger. Don't write it down first.

Bring it to the doctor

The visit goes better with three things in hand: your notes from this page, with dates; a list of every medicine and supplement Mom takes, including over-the-counter ones; and these questions: What could cause changes like these? Which of those causes are treatable? What should we watch for next, and when should we come back?

Many things that look like memory loss have other causes a doctor can find, some of them treatable. That is why the doctor comes before any conclusion, and before any decision about care. This page doesn't say what anything you noticed means, and it doesn't measure Mom or suggest she needs help. It helps you describe what you saw.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down what you've seen. The care interview asks about the rest of Mom's day, area by area, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to the doctor and to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The ten changes are the Alzheimer's Association's list, in general language. What to write down for each is this roadmap's own suggestion.

1. Alzheimer's Association, 10 Early Signs and Symptoms of Alzheimer's and Dementia
2. National Institute on Aging, Memory Problems, Forgetfulness, and Aging
3. National Institute on Aging, How Is Alzheimer's Disease Diagnosed?

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